

English for Daily Life • Answer Key

A2 • Volume 1 • Looking Back • Units 1–1

What is in here

Every closed item in the book, keyed. Every open task with marking points and a sample answer. The source this course is modelled on has no answer key at all; this one is an addition, and the samples are one correct answer rather than the only one.

Where a task is open, mark the form and not the content. Each entry says which form, and most of them say which mistake to expect.

Notes set off in a quote, like this one, are for the person teaching: what the item is really testing, and what learners reliably do wrong.

Contents

Unit	Topic	Grammar	Key
1	The Night the Power Went Out	past continuous vs past simple - while/when	yes

Closed items keyed, by unit

Unit	Closed items	Open tasks	Worked 0. examples
1	—	—	—

Unit 1: The Night the Power Went Out — Answer Key

English for Daily Life • Teacher's section. Open tasks carry a sample answer, not the only correct one.

Warm Up

Warm-up: Words for a Dark Evening

1. b · 2. e · 3. c · 4. a · 5. d Not needed: **f)** *the wire that carries electricity into a building*

Warm-up: Talking About That Evening

1. power cut · 2. switch · 3. candle · 4. freezer

Warm-up: Six People, One Tuesday Evening

1. **A)** Carrying shopping upstairs · 2. **B)** He was sitting in the dark already

Item 2 is the one worth going over. Three of the four options are things he might have been doing; only one explains the *delay*. He noticed nothing for several minutes because he was already sitting in an unlit room, so nothing about his own evening changed. Learners who pick C have read “out” as “out of the building” rather than “out” of the lights.

Part 1 · Vocabulary and Terminology

Part 1: Words for Electricity and Buildings

0. Electricity → the power that arrives at a building and makes everything in it work (*given*)
1. b · 2. e · 3. d · 4. g · 5. c · 6. f · 7. a Not needed: **h**) *the small room where a generator is kept*

The distractor is the one that matters. *Generator* arrives properly in the Part 5 gloss and in the Part 8 story, so a learner who has read ahead will recognise it; a learner who has not will reject **h**) because no word in Column A is a room. Either route is a success.

Part 1: Pronunciation (Track 1.1)

This is the first drill of the level, and it is about hearing, not producing.

The past continuous has three parts — *was*, the *-ing*, and whatever the sentence is about — and English speakers put the beat on the third. *I was READING when the LIGHTS went OUT* carries three stresses and not one of them is on *was*. Reduced, *was* is /wəz/ and *were* is /wə/, which at speed is barely a syllable.

The test to give the class: read *I was reading* aloud at normal speed, then ask how many beats they heard. Most will say two. There are two.

The failure to listen for: learners who have been taught to find the auxiliary will hunt for *was* in a recording, miss it, and conclude the sentence is past simple. Teach them to listen for the *-ing* instead. It is at the end of a stressed word and it is impossible to miss, and it is sufficient: if there is an *-ing*, the sentence is continuous.

Part 1: What Kind of Word Is It?

0. candle → something you can touch (*given*)

The word	Can you touch it?
bulb	yes
darkness	no
electricity	no
freezer	yes
meter	yes
silence	no
supply	no
switch	yes

Supply is the interesting one and the argument is the point of the task. The *cable* carrying the supply is a thing you can touch; the supply itself is not, any more than *traffic* is. Accept a learner who argues the other way if they can say why, and then ask them whether they could point at it.

Part 1: Where Is Each One?

1. c · 2. d · 3. e · 4. a · 5. b Not needed: **f)** *in a locked cupboard in the basement, behind the bikes*

The unused option is not arbitrary. The locked basement cupboard is real, it appears in the Part 1 fill-in and again in Part 9, and nobody in the building has a key for it — which is why nothing useful is in it.

Part 1: Electricity and Buildings — Multiple Choice

1. **A)** meter · 2. **C)** basement · 3. **D)** power cut

Part 1: Vocabulary Fill-in

1. meter · 2. bulb · 3. basement · 4. supply

Item 2 rewards reading the whole sentence. *Bulb* is the only word that somebody would change twice, and the sentence is funny only if the learner notices that changing it was useless.

Part 1: Write About an Evening Without Electricity (short)

Open. Sixty to eighty words, with at least one past continuous. The unit prints a model; this is a second one.

Sample (74 words): *The internet went off for most of a Sunday last year. I was in the middle of a long form that I had been putting off for a month, and of course it had not saved anything. I went for a walk instead, which I had also been putting off for a month. When it came back at six I filled the form in twenty minutes. I had spent four weeks dreading twenty minutes.*

Part 2 · Grammar — Past Continuous vs Past Simple

Part 2: Notice

The difference is finished against unfinished, and it is worth saying out loud that nothing else has changed: same subject, same verb, same time.

closed — the shop was shut before the darkness arrived. Two events in a row. **was closing** — she was in the middle of shutting it. Two events overlapping, with the second interrupting the first.

The teaching point to land: the past continuous is not a politer or a longer past simple. It does one specific job, which is to put an action *in progress* so that something else can land on top of it.

Everything the unit does afterwards depends on learners having that one idea.

Part 2: Grammar Focus Box

Nothing to mark. Two things to check that the class has, because the rest of the unit assumes both.

First, *while* and *when* are not interchangeable in practice even though both sentences mean the same thing. *When* fronts the short finished action; *while* fronts the long one. A learner who writes *while the lights went out* has not made a grammar mistake exactly, but they have put the interruption in the background slot, and the sentence stops meaning what they wanted.

Second, the state verbs. *Know, understand, believe, own, need, want, hear, see, like, hate* do not take the continuous however long the state lasted, and the Grammar Review tests exactly this.

Part 2: Controlled Practice

0. was reading / went (*given*)
1. was coming / went
2. was serving / stopped
3. was watching / turned
4. was sitting / did not notice

Item 4 has two past actions and no interruption: he was sitting, and he did not notice. *Was not noticing* is wrong because *notice* here is the moment of noticing, not a stretch of it.

Part 2: Interrupted or Finished?

0. I was walking home when it started to rain. — **interrupted** (*given*)

The sentence	Interrupted or finished?
She closed the shop and went upstairs.	finished
They were eating when the phone rang.	interrupted
He put the bags down on the landing.	finished

The sentence	Interrupted or finished?
We were waiting for the engineer for an hour.	interrupted

We were waiting for the engineer for an hour is the one learners argue about, and they are right to. Nothing interrupts it. It is *interrupted* because the waiting is presented as a stretch of time rather than a completed event, and that is the same job the continuous does everywhere else. If a learner answers *finished*, ask them what the sentence would be if the engineer had arrived.

Part 2: Correct the Sentence

1. While Maya was reading, the lights **went** out. (*the interrupting action is past simple*)
2. I **knew** the answer before he had finished the question. (*know is a state verb*)
3. Tomas was carrying the bags when he **put** them down. (*the second action interrupts the first*)
4. While we **were** waiting on the stairs, nobody said anything useful. (*the continuous needs was or were*)*

Part 2: Freer Practice

Open. One sentence with *when* and one with *while*, both about the same evening.

Sample: *I was washing up when somebody knocked on the door, and I let them stand there for a moment because my hands were wet. While I was drying them, they knocked again.*

Part 2: Grammar Review

1. **B)** Amina closed the shop, and then the lights went out. · 2. **C)** I was understanding the problem.

→ Harvest: both forms come back in Part 3, where they have to be heard, and in Part 5, where the past continuous carries the whole of the second paragraph.

Part 3 • Listening

Part 3: Tomas Tells It From the Stairs (Track 1.2)

0. True (*given*)
1. **False** — he says he was about halfway up the *second* flight.
2. **True** — “the hum of the lift as well, which is the part I actually noticed”.
3. **Not Given** — he explains why he was careful and says nothing about an accident. Learners who answer False have reasoned, correctly, that he probably did not have one; the point of Not Given is that the text does not say.

Part 3: Amina Keeps the Shop Open (Track 1.3)

0. She was serving a customer. (*given*)
1. The till would not open and she could not weigh anything.
2. Nineteen years.
3. She did not open it once, because a full freezer stays cold for about a day if it is left shut.

Item 3 wants both halves. A learner who says only “she did not open it” has heard the action and missed the reason, and the reason is the only part worth remembering.

Part 3: Four People, Four Versions (Track 1.4)

0. Maya → thought at first that one lamp had failed (*given*)
1. c • 2. a • 3. b Not needed: **d**) *went downstairs to ask the shopkeeper what had happened*

All four speakers use the past continuous for their own evening and the past simple for the moment it stopped, which is the pattern the unit has been building towards. It is worth playing Mr Okonkwo’s account twice: the street lamps staying on for a few seconds is the only detail in the unit that no other account confirms, and the discussion in Part 8 depends on learners being comfortable with that.

Part 4 • Speaking

Part 4: What Were You Doing?

Open pairwork. What you are listening for is the pair of tenses in one sentence, not fluency.

Expect: *I was sitting on the bus when my phone died • While I was cooking, somebody rang the bell • I was waiting about half an hour.* Correct only the shape, and only if the learner has put the interruption in the continuous.

Part 4: Find the Difference (pairwork)

Four differences, and the task is a tense task disguised as a spotting task.

Marking points: ☐ four differences found ☐ the continuous for what was still going on ☐ the past simple for what had finished by the second picture ☐ neither partner looks at the other's picture.

Sample exchange: *In my picture Tomas is standing on the stairs with two bags. — In mine he has put them down, so yours must be the earlier one. — And in mine Amina is still at the till. — Mine too, but she is holding a candle.*

Part 4: The Meeting About the Power Cut

Open group task. Sixty pounds, three options, and the rule that everybody must say what they were doing before they argue for anything.

The task is built so that the strongest argument is the most expensive one. Tomas is right that the stairs are the only dangerous part of the building, and the staircase light costs more than the fund holds. A group that agrees quickly has usually skipped the rule; make them go back and do the “what were you doing” round, because the whole point is that the position each person argues for follows from where they were standing.

Stretch: arguing for another year with nothing. Accept *I know you were stuck on those stairs, and I am still saying wait, because twenty-two pounds of torches we cannot find is worse than one more winter.* The marker is a learner who concedes the other person's experience before disagreeing with it.

Part 4: Mini-Presentation

One minute. “The most useful thing to keep in a drawer.”

Marking points: ☐ one thing, not a list ☐ where it is kept ☐ a story about somebody who needed it ☐ at least one past continuous ☐ about a minute.

Sample: *A pair of scissors. Ours live in the kitchen drawer, on the left, and everybody in the flat knows it. Last year my sister was wrapping a present at eleven at night and the scissors were not there, because I was using them in the other room and had not put them back. She wrapped it with her teeth and told everybody. They have been in the drawer ever since.*

Part 5 • Reading

Part 5: Why the Lights Go Out

- 0. At a substation. (*given*)
- 1. **A)** A problem that had been slowly getting worse
- 2. **D)** Because electricity is difficult to store
- 3. **B)** The ones where somebody knows where the candles are

Item 1 is the hardest in the unit and is worth the time. The text never says that “a fault developed” means a slow failure; it says that is what the phrase is *hiding*, and the evidence is in the three sentences before it, all of them in the past continuous. Learners who choose B have found the control room in the next paragraph and attached it to the wrong sentence.

Part 5: Vocabulary in Context

- 1. c • 2. a • 3. d • 4. f • 5. b Not needed: **e)** *the amount a household pays every three months*

Part 5: Three Buildings, Three Tuesdays

- 0. A generator. (*given*)
- 1. Because the parts that kept working made it harder to admit that the rest had stopped — the lifts were off and the air conditioning was off, but the lights were on, so nobody left.
- 2. They carried on having the meeting.
- 3. One candle behind a shop counter, and a phone with enough battery to tell six people it was not just them.

Item 1 accepts any answer that gets the mechanism: half-working is worse than not working because it removes the excuse. A learner who answers “because the lifts stopped” has listed a fact rather than answered the question.

Part 6 • Writing

Part 6: A Message to the Neighbours (90–110 words)

Marking points: ☐ what you were doing when it happened, in the past continuous ☐ the problem stated once, plainly ☐ one clear thing you are asking for ☐ where it should be kept ☐ 90–110 words.

Sample (96 words): *This is Yuki from the top flat. I was working when the power went out on Tuesday, and the laptop battery meant I did not even notice for half a minute. Then I did, and there was nothing in the flat to see by. I went down two flights in the dark to borrow a candle from a shop that was also in the dark. I would like us to buy torches out of the fund, one for each flat, and I would like them kept inside the flats and not in a box on the landing.*

Part 6: Was the Power Cut Anybody's Fault? (90–110 words)

Marking points: ☐ an opinion in the first sentence ☐ two reasons ☐ *while* or *when* at least once ☐ a distinction between the cut and the response ☐ 90–110 words.

Sample (99 words): *I think the company did its job and the building did not. The engineers were already on their way before anybody at number 14 had called them, and the supply was back in under two hours, which for an underground cable on a cold night is quick. What was not quick was us. Tomas was standing on the stairs for twenty minutes because nobody owned a torch. Amina had the only candle in the building and she had bought it nineteen years ago. The cut was an accident. The twenty minutes were a choice that nobody remembers making.*

Part 6: What Happened on the Stairs (90–110 words)

Marking points: ☐ a beginning, a middle and an end ☐ the background in the past continuous ☐ the events in the past simple ☐ how long it lasted ☐ 90–110 words.

Sample (101 words): *I was on a train that stopped between two stations on a Friday evening in July. I was standing, because everybody was standing, and I was reading over somebody's shoulder because there was nothing else to look at. The lights stayed on and the air conditioning did not. After ten minutes a voice said there was a fault ahead of us and after twenty it said the same thing again in the same words. Nobody complained. A man near the door was telling a long story about a worse journey, and about forty of us listened to all of it.*

Part 6: Reflection — The Thing I Never Get Round To (80–100 words)

Marking points: ☐ one specific thing, not a category ☐ an honest reason it does not happen ☐ one sentence about what would change it ☐ 80–100 words.

Sample (96 words): *I have been meaning to write down where everything is — the stopcock, the meter, the fuse box — since the week I moved in. I know where two of the three are and I have never checked the third. What stops me is that it takes a torch and fifteen minutes and there is never a reason to do it today. What would change it is somebody else needing to know, which is exactly the situation in which I will not be able to tell them. I have written it in the diary for Sunday.*

Part 7 · Real-World File — Reporting a Power Cut

7A: Phrase Bank

1. d · 2. e · 3. f · 4. a · 5. b Not needed: c) *when you want to know how much the repair will cost you*

The unused option is the one learners expect to be there, because a repair at home costs money. A fault on the supply side of the meter does not: it is the company's cable and the company's cost. Saying so is worth thirty seconds.

7B: The Call to the Electricity Company (Track 1.5)

0. The postcode. (*given*)
1. Because the engineers were still looking for the fault when they last reported in.
2. Because eleven people in the building were going to ask her, and she wanted something she could quote.
3. The call goes higher up the list.

The exchange teaches the shape of a useful emergency call: location first, scope second, your own observation third. Amina gives all three in two sentences, and the operator thanks her for it.

7C: Controlled Practice — Making the Call Well

0. Find the emergency number before you need it, not during. — 1 (*given*)

Ask what time to plan for, and then plan for longer. — 4 Give the postcode and say whether the whole street is affected. — 2 Ask for a reference number and write it down. — 5 Say whether anybody at the address needs priority help. — 3

The order is not arbitrary and the reason is worth saying. Priority help comes before the estimate because it changes the estimate. A learner who puts the reference number earlier has not done anything foolish, but they will be asking for a number before there is a job to attach it to.

7D: Role-Play — Telling the Building What You Know

Open pairwork. Student A must pass on three things and admit one.

Marking points: ☐ engineers already sent ☐ no estimated time ☐ the note about the third floor ☐ the unknown admitted, not invented ☐ Student B asks at least two questions.

Sample exchange: *They were already on their way before I rang. — So when? — They would not give me a time, and I am not going to make one up. I have the job number and I can ring again at half past nine. — And if it is still off then? — Then I ring, and whatever they tell me goes on the door.*

The commonest failure is a Student A who, under pressure from an impatient Student B, produces a time that nobody gave them. Listen for *they would not say*.

Stretch: Student B has already called and was told something different. Accept *Then one of us was told wrong, and I would rather find out which than argue about it — I have a reference number, what did they give you?* The marker is a learner who treats the disagreement as information.

7E: Writing — A Note for the Noticeboard (100–120 words)

Marking points: ☐ a first line a passer-by understands in three seconds ☐ what you were told ☐ what is still unknown, said plainly ☐ what you will do next, with a time ☐ 100–120 words.

Sample (104 words): *Thursday — the lift is out, and it is not coming back this week. I spoke to the company at nine this morning. A part has to come from somewhere else and they were not able to tell me where from, so the engineer who looked at it on Tuesday has gone away again. They are saying Monday or Tuesday and I would not plan around either. I have the job number in flat 3 if anybody needs it. If nobody has rung by Monday lunchtime I will ring them, and I will put whatever they say up here the same afternoon. Yuki.*

Part 8 · Global Story — The Night Buenos Aires Went Quiet

0. It was the only cool thing in the flat. (*given*)
1. The silence that arrived with the darkness.
2. Because they were already working at their limit and could not take what the failed one had been carrying.
3. The sound of every television in the building coming on at once.

Item 3 is the detail that makes the story a story rather than an account, and it is worth asking the class why. Every television was still switched on and still tuned to whatever had been playing at eight forty-three, so the building woke up in the middle of six hours earlier. Nobody had turned anything off, because nobody had been given the chance.

Part 8: Vocabulary in Context

1. c · 2. d · 3. a · 4. f · 5. b Not needed: e) *the room where a generator is kept*

Part 8: Discussion

Open, in threes. Elena's mother opened the front door.

Marking points: ☐ each learner uses one of the three frames ☐ an answer about Elena's building ☐ an answer about their own ☐ a reason for the difference.

Sample: What I noticed about this story is that nobody asked her to open the door. The part I would find hardest is standing on a landing with people I have never spoken to. In my experience, people in my building would wait inside and listen at the door, and I think the difference is not the heat but whether you already know the names.

There is no right answer, and the frames are there to stop the conversation from becoming one. What usually comes out is that opening the door was obviously right in that building and would be unthinkable in several of the buildings the class lives in.

Part 9 · Close to Home — Three Weeks Later at Number 14

0. Painting the front door. (*given*)
1. Because it is the only part of the building where somebody could actually be hurt.
2. That the fund has bought nothing in three years, and a box of torches is something you can put your hand on tonight.
3. Because she thinks the problem was not equipment but that nobody had thought about it.

Part 9: Decision Task

Open. Sixty to eighty words, one option chosen, and an answer to the strongest objection.

Marking points: ☐ one option, named ☐ a reason that is not just the price ☐ the strongest argument against it, stated fairly ☐ an answer to it ☐ 60–80 words.

Sample (78 words): *I would spend nothing, which I know sounds like doing nothing. The fund has sixty-one pounds and the building has no plan, and a plan is the only one of the three that would have changed Tuesday. Amina had a candle because she had thought about it nineteen years ago. The strongest argument against me is Tomas's, because a plan does not light a staircase, and my answer is that it tells him whose job the staircase is.*

All three options are defensible and the marking is about the fourth bullet, not the first. A learner who chooses the staircase light must deal with the fund being thirty pounds short; one who chooses the torches must deal with Tomas's objection that a torch in a box in the dark is a torch you cannot find; one who chooses the plan must deal with the fact that a plan is not a light.

Part 10 • Review and Can-Do

Part 10: Spiral Review

0. candle (*given*)
1. power cut • 2. meter • 3. was serving • 4. basement • 5. While • 6. supply • 7. darkness

Item 3 is the only one that tests the unit's grammar rather than its vocabulary, and item 5 is the only one that tests the conjunction. Both are in the bank, so a learner who has the vocabulary can get them by elimination; ask them afterwards why *while* and not *when*, and the answer — because the shouting and the standing were both going on — is the unit in one sentence.

Part 10: Can-Do

Self-assessment. Nothing to mark. The fifth line is the Plus one, and a Core-only class should not be asked to tick it.

Part 10: Glossary

Ten words: power cut • electricity • candle • darkness • switch • freezer • meter • supply • bulb • basement

All ten appear at least three times before Part 10 and none of them appears in any A2 glossary. *Supply* and *darkness* are the two that learners will have met without noticing, because both do most of their work in the Part 5 reading rather than in a vocabulary task.